A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies

Bartolomé de las Casas · 1542

Source: Bartolomé de las Casas, A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies (1542). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> A Spanish friar's searing eyewitness indictment of the cruelty of the conquistadors toward Native peoples — a founding document of the movement to protect indigenous rights and a source of the “Black Legend” of Spanish colonization.

It was upon these gentle lambs, imbued by the Creator with all the qualities we have mentioned, that from the very first day they clapped eyes on them the Spanish fell like ravening wolves upon the fold, or like tigers and savage lions who have not eaten meat for days. The pattern established at the outset has remained unchanged to this day, and the Spaniards still do nothing save tear the natives to shreds, murder them and inflict upon them untold misery.